

Teaching Players What to See

NOVEMBER 4 • PRACTICE PRIORITIES • TRANSITION • DECISIONS • PRESSURE

This Week

1. **What Deserves Your Practice Time?**
2. **Build Habits Before Adding More**
3. **Train Decisions Against Defenders**
4. **Use Continuous Transition Games**
5. **Know What Can Wait**
6. **Question of the Day and Program Recognition**

Coaching Focus

Writing down everything we want to teach is easy. Deciding what deserves today's practice time is harder.

Every drill, explanation, and new action takes minutes. Those minutes have to come from somewhere. The standard for our plan should be simple: what do our players need to do well when we begin competing?

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What Deserves Your Practice Time?

After our first week of practices, I keep returning to three questions. They help me decide what belongs in the plan, what needs live competition, and what can wait.

The Possibilities

- Transition offense
- Spacing
- Finishing
- Shooting
- Pressure defense
- What to do when the first option is taken away

All of these areas matter. The challenge is deciding which ones matter most right now.

The Question Behind the Plan

What do our players need to do well when we start competing?

The answer should guide the minutes we give to drills, teaching, film, live play, and conditioning. Practice time should reflect the habits and decisions that will show up most often in games.

1 What Needs to Become a Habit?

Our early priorities have included spacing out of transition, developing an attack mindset, finishing, and shooting. We have also worked on our made-shot and missed-shot breaks.

These things need repetition. Players have to recognize their responsibilities and get moving without waiting for directions.

Explaining something gives players an introduction. They still need opportunities to execute it, make mistakes, receive feedback, and try again.

"We covered that" does not mean we can do it consistently in a game.



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Make the Foundation Dependable

Before adding another layer, I want to know whether our foundation is becoming dependable.

- Do we get to our spots?
- Are we ready to attack on the catch?
- Can we maintain spacing when the possession gets messy?
- Do we respond immediately when possession changes?

If those things are still breaking down, they deserve more practice time. Repetition of the right fundamentals creates consistency and confidence.

Build Train Compete

Build habits through purposeful repetition. Train decisions in game-like situations. Compete with pressure, pace, and accountability.

The goal is not to keep practice busy. The goal is to make our most important behaviors dependable when the game becomes fast and uncomfortable.

2 What Needs to Happen Against Defenders?

A drill can look organized when everyone knows where the ball is going. Add a defender, and the timing changes.

The pass disappears. The driving lane closes. A player catches and hesitates. Those moments give us information about what players can recognize and execute under pressure.

Advantage Games

Some of my favorite drills are 3-on-2 and 4-on-3. The numbers advantage gives players opportunities to attack, draw a defender, and find the open teammate.

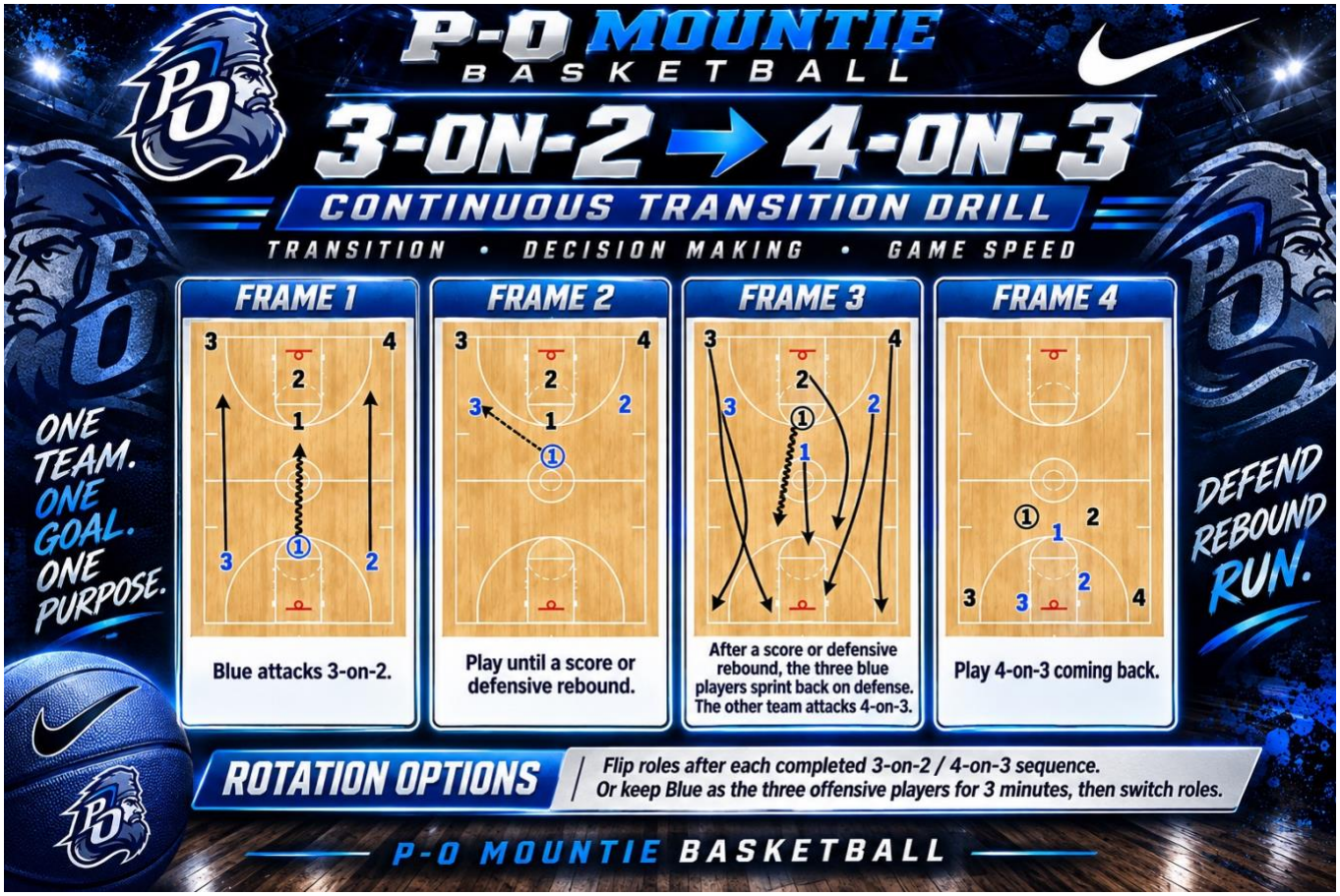
Players still have to decide when to finish and when to make the next pass. An advantage requires a good decision. Holding the ball too long or crowding the lane gives the defense time to recover.

- Attack before the defense becomes organized.
- Create a passing angle after the paint touch.
- Maintain space while the ball handler makes the read.
- Finish when the defense does not stop the ball.

Continuous Transition Games

I also love 2-on-2, 3-on-3, and 4-on-4 continuous. Players receive repeated opportunities to attack, defend, and transition into the next possession.

With fewer players on the floor, everyone has to be involved. We can work on spacing, finishing, passing, communication, and decision-making within the same game.



- Are we giving the ball handler space?
- Are we creating a passing angle?
- When possession changes, can we respond immediately?

If we want quick decisions in games, practice has to give players decisions to make.

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3 What Can Wait?

This is a difficult question for coaches. We see an action we like. We remember something we want to install. We think about every defense we might face.

There is always something else to add. But every addition asks players to process more information and takes time away from something else.

Before Adding It

- Will this help us right now?
- Are our players ready to execute it?
- What priority will lose time if we add it?
- Does the new action strengthen our system or simply add more information?

Sometimes the answer is yes. Other times, we need those minutes for transition spacing, finishing through pressure, or making the next pass on time.

Having something on my coaching list does not automatically make it a priority for today.

The discipline to wait can be just as important as the creativity to add.

Planning Your Next Practice

Our practice priorities come from what we see on the floor. Right now, transition is an early-season emphasis.

We want to run for a layup, arrive in space, and flow into our slot reads and Neutral when the layup is not there.

We do some form of transition work every day. When it is a major focus, we give it more time.

Teach Then Apply

We teach the Fingers and Fan slot reads before asking players to apply them in live games. Then we build through 2-on-2, 3-on-3, and 4-on-4 so players can recognize those reads against defenders.

Continuous Format Numbers

- 2-on-2 continuous: 8 players
- 3-on-3 continuous: 12 players
- 4-on-4 continuous: 16 players

Choose the format that fits your available players and the decision you want to train. More players do not automatically make the drill better.

The best practice plan gives players repeated opportunities to build habits, make decisions, and compete.

Question of the Day

November 3 If you could only have one defensive principle, what would it be?

Make Every Catch a Dribble

My principle would be: make every catch a dribble.

That means applying nonstop pressure and constantly disrupting the offense from getting what it wants. It minimizes off-the-catch threes and forces players to make decisions off the dribble while uncomfortable.

This principle gives our players a clear purpose. Close out with urgency, take away the immediate shot, and force the ball handler into a pressured decision.

- Pressure the catch without giving up a straight-line drive.
- Make the offense put the ball on the floor.
- Communicate early so the next defender is ready.
- Turn uncomfortable decisions into rushed passes and difficult shots.

A defensive principle becomes valuable when every player can recognize and execute it.

Varsity Fall League

Congratulations to the Boys Varsity Team for finishing 4-4 in this year's State College Varsity Fall League.

This is the first time in three years that our program has finished at .500 in this league. The result reflects the work, commitment, and support of our players, coaches, and families.



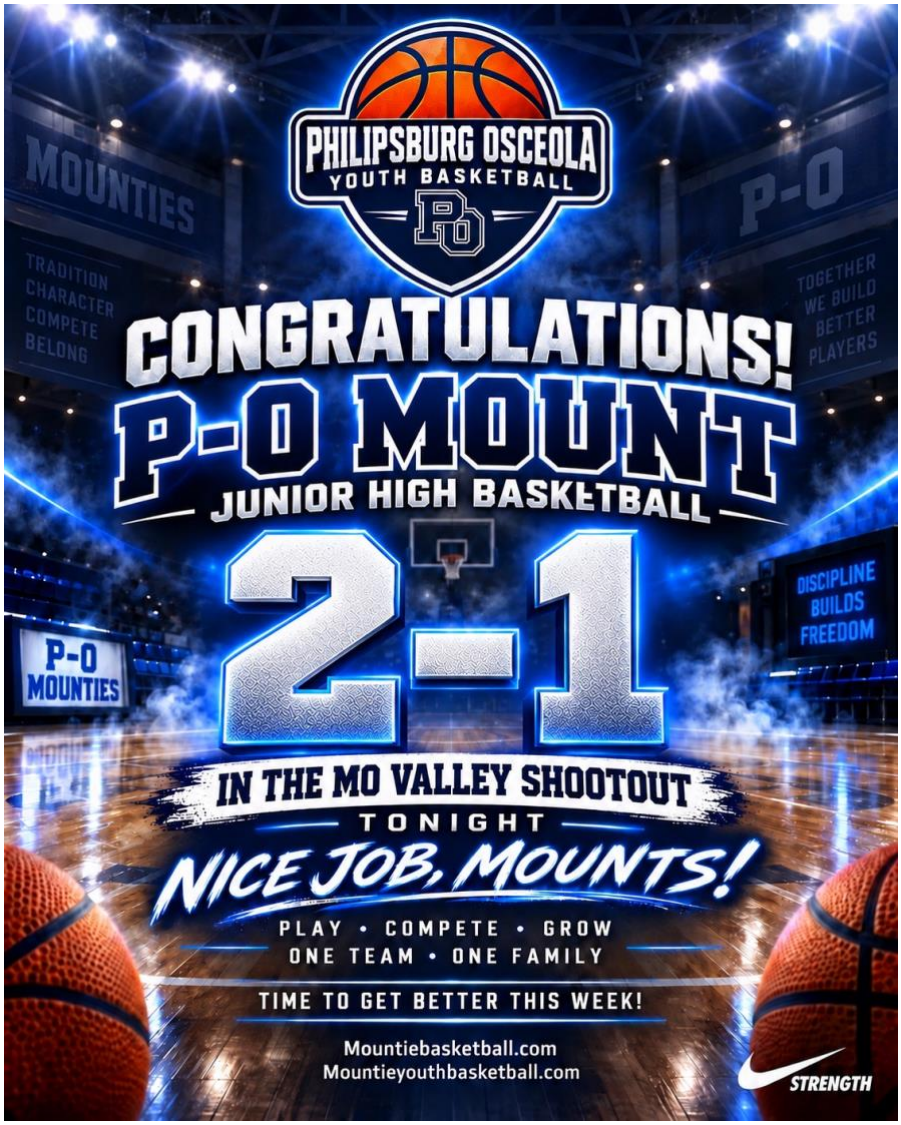
The program is moving in the right direction. Keep working, competing, and growing together.

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Junior High Shootout

Congratulations to the Boys Junior High Team for finishing 2-1 in this year's Mo Valley Junior High Shootout.

The group competed, responded to adversity, and gained valuable experience that will help prepare them for the season.



Thank you to every parent, player, and coach for the continued trust and support.

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Mountie Website Links

Stay connected with every part of the P-O Basketball program. Use the links below for varsity news, youth basketball, the sports complex project, Central PA Lions, and the P-O Select Team League.

Varsity Basketball

Youth Basketball

Little Mounties Sports Complex

TJ's Central PA Lions

P-O Select Team League

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Coach Anderson

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